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Digital activism, engagement coordination, and algorithmic imaginaries in the EXÉRCITO DO LULA WhatsApp channel

Technical-scientific report

Observation window: October 5–25, 2026

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TECHNICAL-SCIENTIFIC REPORT

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labhdufba@gmail.com · Salvador · October 2026

Credits

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How to cite

NASCIMENTO, L.; BRASIL, E.; SODRÉ, R. A.; CESARINO, L.; KALIL, I.; BARRETO, T.; BELAS, L. Digital activism, engagement coordination, and algorithmic imaginaries in the EXÉRCITO DO LULA WhatsApp channel. Salvador: LABHDUFBA, 2026.

Data availability

The data, coding and figures underlying this report are openly available at: https://github.com/LABHDUFBA/exercito-do-lula

Executive summary

This report examines the activity of the EXÉRCITO DO LULA WhatsApp channel between 5 and 25 October 2026, encompassing the period from the day after the first round through the presidential runoff, held on 25 October. The window contains 1.278 posts, with a strong concentration on 17 and 18 October: the two days accounted for 743 publications, equivalent to 58,1% of the total. A dataset of 1.018 content units — 856 texts, 138 audio files, and 24 videos, dated from 16 to 25 October — was fully coded according to the communicative function present: requested actions, platforms mentioned, and the presence of markers of a) militarization, b) urgency, c) “prova social” (the invocation of scale, counts, and metrics as evidence of collective strength), and d) algorithmic imaginaries (explicit beliefs about the operation of algorithms and platforms that guide observable conduct).

Among the 1.018 units, 206 coordination instructions and 170 mobilization messages were identified. Militarized language appeared in 211 units; urgency, in 247; social proof, in 157; and algorithmic imaginaries, in 44. These results indicate that the channel operated as a communicative coordination hub for distributed digital activism: it defined tasks, synchronized interventions, disseminated reports and screenshots of metrics as evidence of performance — monitoring evidenced by the published content itself, not by independent auditing of the platforms — modulated temporalities of urgency, and coordinated actions across WhatsApp, Instagram, X, and other platforms. This operation transformed affordances of circulation, visibility, and interaction into resources for political coordination (Bucher & Helmond, 2018), approximating the forms of digital activist work described by Kreiss (2016) and Karpf (2016). The corpus demonstrates the explicit coordination of engagement by human participants, but does not permit inferences about effective reach, electoral conversion, automation, or participants’ identities.

The channel should be understood within a multiplatform ecosystem in which content, metrics, and commands circulate across interdependent infrastructures (Poell, Nieborg & Van Dijck, 2019). In the episode of the Band debate, the articulation between television and messaging reveals a dynamic characteristic of the hybrid media system, marked by the interaction between traditional media and digital platforms (Chadwick, 2013). The concepts of the digital body of the king, fractal personhood, and digital populism (Cesarino, 2019; 2020a; 2020b), in turn, make it possible to compare the observed activist grammar with that described in the literature on Bolsonarist networks, while preserving the ideological difference between the cases.

Object, scope, and method

The object of analysis is the communication published on the EXÉRCITO DO LULA WhatsApp channel, with a focus on observable forms of mobilization, engagement coordination, cross-platform circulation, identity construction, and the dissemination of political attacks or claims. Because this is a channel rather than a conversation group, the corpus records only posts issued by the channel. It does not include dialogues among participants, individual responses, recipient lists, or complete sharing trajectories. This architecture conditions the possibilities for action and observation: the channel’s

affordances facilitate centralized broadcasting, but do not make it possible to reconstruct users' reception or appropriation of the messages (Bucher & Helmond, 2018).

The main scope covers the period from 5 to 25 October 2026. The material derives from a snapshot prepared on 29 October 2026 from a decrypted local backup, comprising 1.382 records in the full dataset. The analytical window brings together 1.278 posts, of which 856 contain native text, 138 are audio files (108,7 minutes transcribed), 24 are videos (25,8 minutes, transcribed and examined frame by frame), and 55 are images with OCR. All media files were downloaded, and their SHA-256 hashes were checked against the available index.

Created on 14 April 2026 by federal deputy André Janones (Rede-MG), the channel gained national scale after the first presidential round: it reached approximately 10,8 million subscribers at the peak of the runoff and became the subject of a TSE decision ordering its suspension (11/10); its operation was subsequently maintained under a formal severance from the campaign (17/10) (BBC News Brasil, 26/10/2026; Agência Brasil, 11/10/2026; O Globo, 17/10/2026). This report analyzes only the content published on the channel within the defined window, not the size of its audience.

The full coding covered 1.018 units from 16 to 25 October, including all audio and video files, as well as the complete texts from the peak days and the recruitment period. The procedure was assisted by GPT-5.6 Sol and LABHDUFBA researchers. Decisive excerpts were checked against the original files, subsamples underwent independent double verification, and consistency between functional labels and markers was audited. The functional categories follow the typology validated in the pilot sample (n=299): coordination instruction, platform engagement, mobilization, identity/scale, attack, news claim (a factual assertion about third parties presented in a news-like tone, without a verifiable source in the corpus), positive propaganda, humor/meme, conversion/ recruitment, metareflexive (messages whose object is the channel's own communication: corrections, performance assessments, and decisions about what to publish), and other. Throughout the text, codes E1–E11 refer to the empirical episodes described in the section "Empirical episodes."

The reliability of the procedure was assessed through independent, blind double coding of 105 of the 1.018 units (45 texts, 45 audio files, and 15 videos), a deterministic sample stratified by modality. Percentage agreement was 64,1% for the principal function, and Cohen's kappa was 0,577 — disagreements concentrated at the boundaries between coordination instruction, platform engagement, and mobilization, conceptually adjacent categories. The cross-cutting binary markers showed higher agreement: militarization 90,2% (kappa 0,783), urgency 92,4% (kappa 0,826), social proof 87,0% (kappa 0,526), and algorithmic imaginary 94,6% (kappa 0,679). Disagreements were not adjudicated by a third coder: the principal function is treated in the text as a tendency, and the binary markers as indicators with different degrees of reliability — from moderate (social proof, κ=0,526) to almost perfect (urgency, κ=0,826). The 1.018 units were initially classified by GPT-5.6 Sol under a closed protocol; human validation consisted of the independent double coding described above, the checking of decisive excerpts against the original files, and the audit of consistency between labels. A subsample of 15 audio transcriptions (the eight longest and seven deterministic cases) was independently retranscribed, with an average similarity of 1,0 across passages.

The composition of the subcorpus followed inclusive criteria: all publications in the window with analyzable content were coded, without sampling based on substantive criteria. This resulted in 1.018 coding units from 1.013 publications: 856 text units (831 text messages and 25 image and video captions), 138 audio units (all audio files in the window, transcribed), and 24 video units (five video publications with captions generated two units each — caption and content). The 265 publications without interpretable material were excluded: 227 stickers, 27 images without captions, and 11 system records and interactive effects. The 299 pilot units served only to calibrate the protocol and were recoded in the full pass.

Temporal dynamics and corpus composition

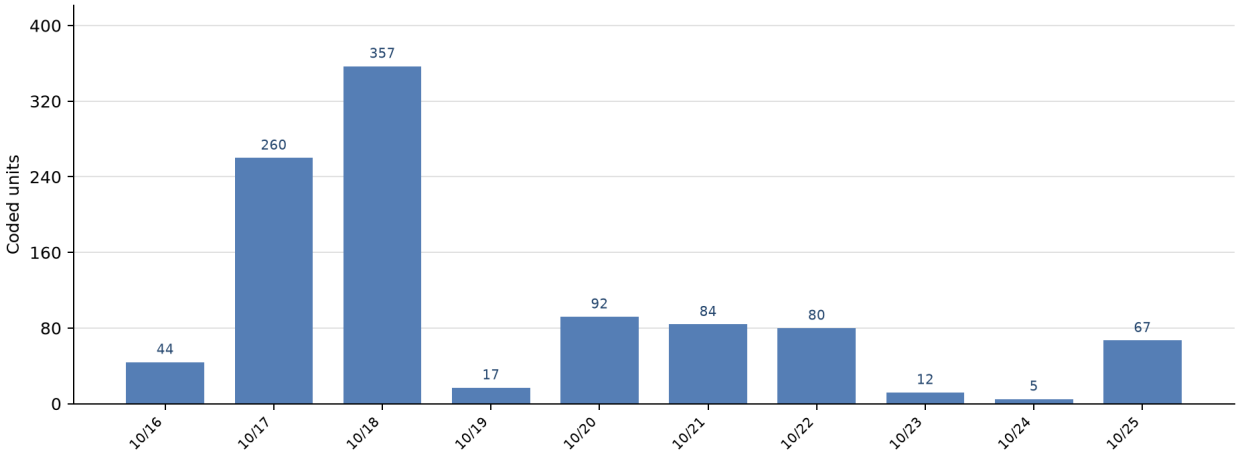


Figure 1. Units coded by day (16–25/10, n=1.018). Vertical axis begins at zero.

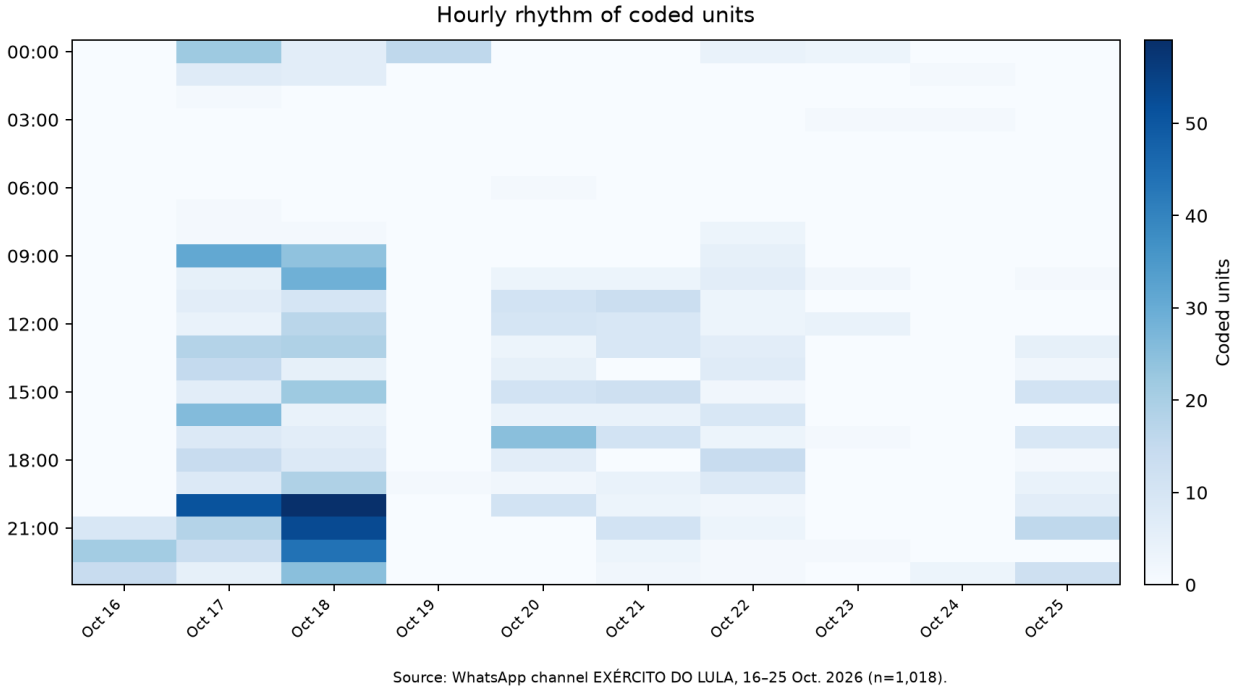


Figure 1a. Hourly posting rhythm of coded units on the EXÉRCITO DO LULA channel, 16–25 October 2026 (n=1.018). Each cell represents the number of units per hour, in Brasília time.

The temporal distribution was highly asymmetric. The days of 17 and 18 October concentrated 743 posts: 370 on the first day and 373 on the second, equivalent to 58,1% of the publications in the period. In the full coding, 17 and 18 October account for 617 of the 1.018 units (60,6%). The concentration is also apparent in the hourly rhythm of the coded units: on 18/10, 59 units were recorded between 20:00 and 21:00, 53 between 21:00 and 22:00, and 44 between 22:00 and 23:00; on 17/10, there were 51 units between 20:00 and 21:00 (Figure 1a). Considered alongside orders to follow the channel and post in sequence (E3), these bursts indicate a choreography of mobilization organized in temporal blocks, in which centralized commands seek to synchronize distributed actions (Gerbaudo, 2012).

Of the 1.278 publications recorded in the period, 83,0% were text or links (without media), while 10,8% were audio files, 4,3% images, and 1,9% videos. In addition to formats, 115 URLs were identified in the native text of publications, of which 91 (79,1%) directed users to Instagram. This finding makes it possible to characterize the presence of external links in the set of messages and identify the concentration of referrals toward a specific platform. The analysis of the relationship between the channel and other platforms, as well as of mobilization strategies directed toward those environments, will be developed in the section on cross-platform circulation.

In the analyzed window, the sum of the values recorded in the forwards_count field totaled 16.870.308. This field is nominally associated with the count of post forwards, whereas view_count is associated with the count of views. However, because the correspondence between these fields and WhatsApp's original metrics was not validated in the documentation of the collection system, their values are presented only as descriptive attributes of the dataset. They are not used as measures of effective circulation, audience, or reach. Additionally, because they are counters recorded at the time of collection, it is not possible to attribute all recorded interactions exclusively to the period analyzed.

Command architecture: coordination and synchronization

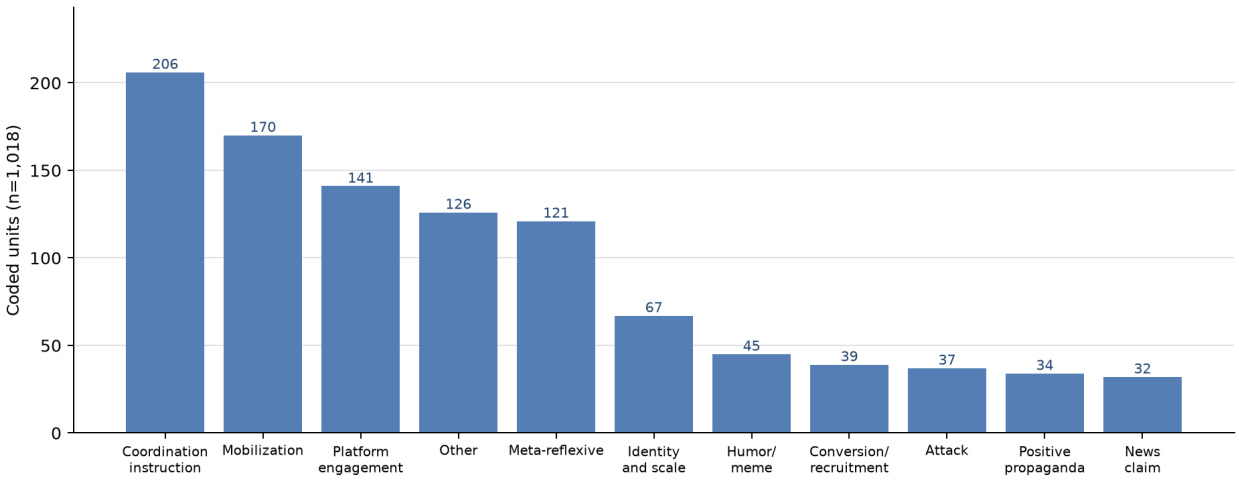


Figure 2. Principal function of the 1.018 fully coded units. The category "outro" (other) (n=126; 12,4% of units) includes isolated reactions (emojis, ellipses), attention calls without political content, and links without framing.

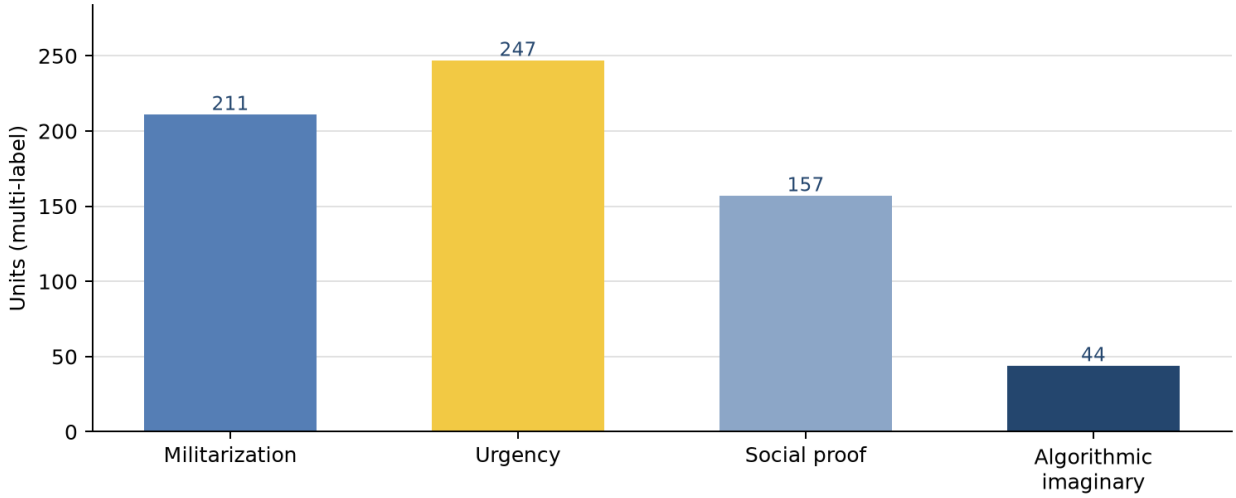


Figure 3. Cross-cutting markers (multi-label): militarization, urgency, social proof, and algorithmic imaginary.

Coordination becomes clearer in messages that break engagement down into simple, sequential, and temporally bounded tasks. On 16 October, an audio file instructed listeners to like, comment with a specific phrase, share, send to contacts and groups, and copy the link to an Instagram video (E1); minutes later, a text defined it as a collective duty to make the following message the video with the most likes in the first 60 minutes (E2). On 17 October, audio files published between 9:19 and 9:44 prescribed posting in order, required continuous attention to the channel, and reported the successive rise of hashtags at intervals of minutes (E3). Instructions and performance reports thus formed a recurring operational cycle: command, expected execution, monitoring of indicators, and communication of results (E6).

In the full coding, 206 of the 1.018 units (20,2%) have coordination instruction as their principal function, while 170 (16,7%) are mobilizations. Requested actions total: sharing (84), hashtags (70), watching (60), following/joining (43), liking (27), forwarding (22), commenting (18), street events (12), voting (5). The corpus records an explicit chain of commands that connects actions, content, channels, and defined temporal horizons. It involves coordinating human participation to amplify public signals of engagement, rather than unguided spontaneous interaction. A literal example: on 17 October, an audio file published at 16:58 prescribed “recebeu, já vai curtir, comentar e compartilhar [...] daqui um, dois minutinhos, já vai ser o post, mas é pra vocês arrebentar”.

This operation constitutes digital activist work: the calling, orientation, execution, measurement, and reactivation of platform-mediated political actions (Kreiss, 2016; Karpf, 2016). The channel performed a choreography-of-mobilization function by establishing what to do, in what order, in which environment, and with what urgency (Gerbaudo, 2012). The messages do not prove that participants followed the commands, nor do they permit measurement of the effective execution of tasks; they do, however, demonstrate a deliberate attempt to produce coordinated conduct. The reduction of mobilization costs and the capacity to synchronize discrete actions likewise do not demonstrate the existence of enduring organizational capacity (Tufekci, 2017).

Authentic coordination and the strategic production of visibility

The debate over coordinated inauthentic behavior (CIB) requires distinguishing operations based on false identities, spam, or artificial manipulation from legitimate practices of collective organization. In the technical opinion of InternetLab, Aláfia Lab, Artigo 19, and Conectas Direitos Humanos (2026), standardized messages, shared hashtags, and simultaneous calls do not, in isolation, demonstrate inauthenticity; for WhatsApp channels, nor can control over users who voluntarily reproduce messages on other platforms be presumed. This caveat is crucial to avoid turning political coordination into an automatic suspicion of illegality.

In the case analyzed, however, the authenticity of participants does not amount to an absence of strategic direction. The hashtag offensive of 17 October (E2) and the instruction to alternate posts among three pages in order to “descansar o algoritmo, não flopar” demonstrate an organized attempt to produce public signals of engagement and compete for cross-platform visibility. The corpus does not demonstrate automation, fraud, alteration of recommendation systems, compliance with the instructions, or electoral impact. It does, however, demonstrate a centralized infrastructure for issuing commands aimed at coordinating distributed actions. Coordination, authenticity, and the strategic production of visibility are therefore distinct dimensions: the absence of demonstrated inauthenticity does not mean the absence of strategic organization of political visibility.

Collective identity, emotions, and discipline

Collective identity was produced through militarized language, numerical targets, appeals to urgency, and visual demonstrations of scale. The channel’s name and the recurrence of “tropa”, “soldados”, “missão”, “batalha”, and “ataque” reframed ordinary platform actions as coordinated individual contributions to a collective contest (E5, E6). In the full coding, militarization appears in 211 units (20,7%), urgency in 247 (24,3%), social proof in 157 (15,4%), and algorithmic imaginary in 44 (4,3%).

These markers are concentrated in command functions. Urgency appears in 79 of the 206 coordination instructions, and militarization in 63; mobilization adds 67 units of urgency and 45 of militarization. Urgency and militarization therefore operate as mechanisms of communicative discipline: the former compressed the time available for deliberation, while the latter transformed dispersed tasks into obligations tied to a common identity and purpose. This combination mobilized affective repertoires of coordination, in which emotion, belonging, and circulation mutually reinforce one another (Papacharissi, 2015), within the conditions of visibility and connection characteristic of networked publics (Boyd, 2010).

The militarized grammar constituted a communicative repertoire for concentrated and coordinated action, without any evidence of military organization. Its most productive interpretation lies in the concepts of fractal personhood and the digital body of the king: political identity reproduces itself as a fractal kaleidoscope that articulates followers and leadership as a single “body” (Cesarino, 2019, 2020a, 2020b). The comparison with Cesarino examines formal similarities in communicative mechanisms — the possible

circulation of organizational repertoires across antagonistic political fields — without assuming equivalence of projects, organizational structures, or ideological orientations. In the case analyzed, activism operated “em nome de” a political ecosystem assembled around the charismatic figure of President Lula, whose messages discursively associated the campaign with the actions of the “Exército” through André Janones — an association present in the published content itself, without the corpus permitting the documentation of institutional coordination between the campaign and the channel. Humor and antagonism reinforced boundary-making between the Lula-supporting “digital body” and its antagonists: 45 humor/meme units and 37 attack units among the coded material condensed “nós-eles” divisions (Wedderburn et al., 2024).

Algorithmic imaginaries and the production of visibility

The channel displayed practices of reflexivity about the operation of platforms, expressed in the elaboration and circulation of practical theories about recommendation algorithms and visibility mechanisms, shared with followers as tacit knowledge and converted into simple operational instructions. On 17 October, for example, an audio file explained the alternating use of three pages to “descansar o algoritmo” and avoid a decline in performance (E4). The sociological relevance of these conceptions does not require proof that the algorithm works exactly as described. They constituted algorithmic imaginaries because they guided observable conduct in the dynamic environments of platforms — intervals between actions, page rotation, and hashtag synchronization — in relation to systems whose ordering remains opaque to users (Gillespie, 2018).

Metrics functioned simultaneously as evaluation tools and symbolic objects. Graphics (graphic pieces disseminated by the channel) featuring targets of millions of participants, screenshots of trending topics, and growing subscriber targets transformed numbers into mobilization resources and internal evidence of effectiveness (E6, E8). In this circuit, quantified visibility fueled new calls and sustained the perception of collective strength, bringing political mobilization closer to measurable circulation on platforms (Castells, 2012; Dean, 2010). The proclaimed results, however, cannot be attributed solely to collective will: they depend on opaque infrastructures of selection, recommendation, and ordering that the corpus does not permit us to audit.

Cross-platform circulation

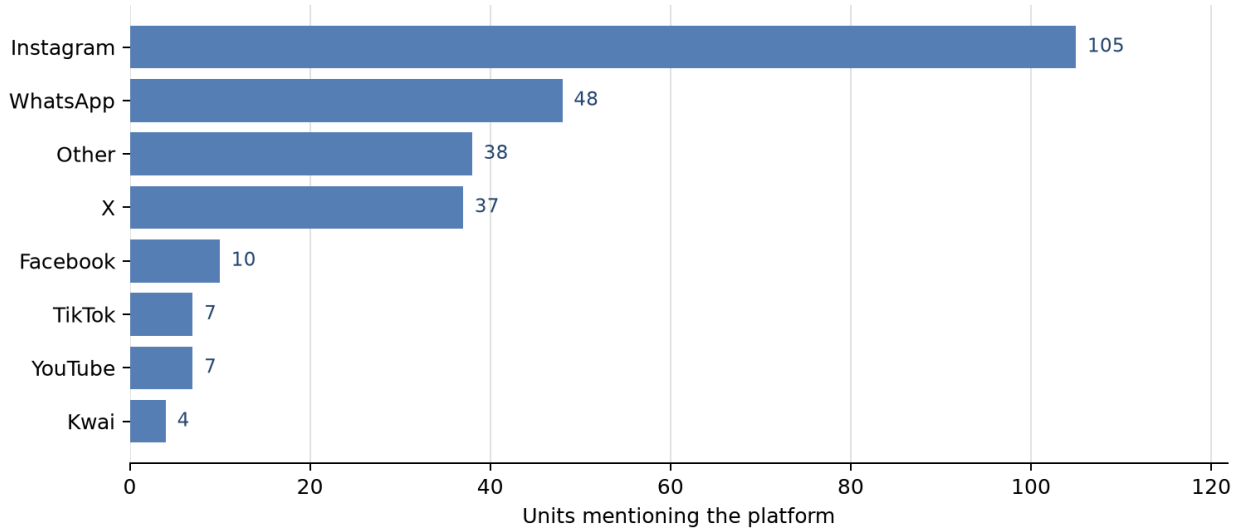


Figure 4. Platforms mentioned in the coded units.

WhatsApp — one of the most widespread digital platforms in Brazilians' everyday lives, present on approximately 98% of the smartphones of surveyed users and accessed daily or almost daily by 97% of those who have the application (Mobile Time; Opinion Box, 2026) — functioned as a command point for coordinated interventions on other platforms. On 17 October, an audio file announced the occupation of TikTok, Facebook, X, and Kwai as "armadas de ataque" fronts (E5); on the 18th, a text called for a "mutirão de seguidores" on profiles in the Lula/PT ecosystem on Instagram, X, and WhatsApp (E7). In the full coding, 105 units mention Instagram, 37 X, 10 Facebook, 7 TikTok, 7 YouTube, and 4 Kwai, while 70 requested actions involved hashtags. The distribution reveals an architecture in which coordination concentrated in messaging sought to produce effects of reach, indexing, and visibility in distinct environments.

This circulation expressed the platformization of political action, whereby activist practices are reorganized by the infrastructures, rules, and visibility models of multiple interdependent platforms (Poell, Nieborg & Van Dijck, 2019). External links, formats, forwarding mechanisms, and hashtag indexing offered possibilities for action and, simultaneously, delimited what could be coordinated in each environment — affordances that emerge from the relation among technical resources, situated uses, and participants' interpretations (Bucher & Helmond, 2018). The messaging platform was thus part of a broader ecosystem (Van Dijck, Poell e De Waal, 2018; Plantin et al., 2018), consistent with the logic of a hybrid media system in which content and strategies circulate across distinct architectures (Chadwick, 2013). The rotation among three Instagram pages to "descansar o algoritmo" and "não flopar" (E4) illustrates this double determination: the infrastructure delimited possible rhythms and volumes, and participants formulated practical theories about its operation.

The channel retained recognizable internal codes while seeking repercussion in more open public spaces. This passage between environments did not reproduce a single audience: messages coordinated in a relatively bounded space were reframed by different interfaces, publics, and circulation logics. The dynamic is potentially consistent with the refracted publics described by Nascimento et al. (2022): the corpus demonstrates instructions aimed

at producing circulation among distinct publics and sociotechnical environments, although the effective transformation of the composition of those publics was not directly observed.

Empirical episodes

The hashtag battle of 17 October

The day of 17 October, with 370 publications, recorded the second-highest daily volume in the window (the highest, 373, occurred on 18 October, during the Band debate), concentrating a coordinated hashtag offensive together with a coordinated action for “soldados” to post a photograph of themselves wearing green and yellow at exactly 9 a.m. on 17 October. Audio files published between 9:19 and 9:44 prescribed the sequential posting of markers, continuous attention to trends, and rounds of checking whether the hashtag had entered the trending topics (E3). Some examples of the hashtags mobilized in this episode are:

#OVerdeAmareloENosso

#RetomamosNossasCores

#NossaBandeiraEVerdeEAmarela

#Somos5MilhoesDeSoldadosDoLula

#LulaVaiTerQueComprarCelular

These examples, among others identified in the corpus, were associated with messages that organized mobilization in stages, with commands such as “Primeira batalha vencida”, “Agora vamos pro terceiro”, and “Próxima missão”. The sequence of calls reveals a dynamic in which the channel distributed tasks, established rhythms of participation, and presented signals of completion for each stage, configuring a choreography of collective mobilization (Gerbaudo, 2012).

The operation also involved instructions for “descanso do algoritmo,” through page rotation (E4), and for circulation on other platforms (E5). Graphics that linked the channel to expressions such as “5 milhões”, “soldados”, and “rumo à virada”, together with a screenshot of trending topics, functioned as demonstrations of success (E6). The episode demonstrates the dynamics of a hybrid media system (Chadwick, 2013), in which algorithmic rankings were turned into arenas of contestation, while the channel coordinated interventions, monitored their results, and recirculated them as evidence of its own performance.

The Band debate on 18 October

The second peak day (373 posts) synchronized the channel’s activity with the presidential debate on Rede Bandeirantes. Hashtags and reactions were distributed to intervene in public repercussion, while screenshots or claims of performance on other platforms returned to WhatsApp as social proof (E6, E10). Some examples of hashtags mobilized during the debate were:

#LulaDandoShowNaBand

#RespondeOLulaFlavio

#FlavioSocioDoCareca

#LulaPaiDoBolsaFamilia

The calls were accompanied by commands such as “SUBAM AGORA!!!!”, “POSTEM UM DE CADA VEZ”, and “NÃO DESMOBILIZEM!”, demonstrating the attempt to sustain coordinated participation during the debate. In addition to hashtags, the channel instructed users to share clips and images in Instagram stories and on X, articulating television repercussion with the circulation of content on other platforms. These examples form part of a broader set of mobilization messages identified in the corpus, demonstrating the articulation between television, social media, and messaging according to the logic of the hybrid media system (Chadwick, 2013).

An audio file published at 20:26 claimed that the opposing camp had hired two thousand people to produce clips in real time (E10). The assertion has no verifiable source in the corpus and is recorded exclusively as published content, not as evidence of the alleged event.

The post-electoral “última missão” (E11)

Still on 25 October, before the confirmation of the result, the channel anticipated a task for after the election: at 18:56, a text prescribed: “Última missão: na hora que se confirmar a vitória acachapante do presidente Lula, vocês por favor desenterrem todos os tuítes e posts aqui do canal onde eu afirmava pra vocês CATEGORICAMENTE que a eleição estava ganha, e com uma diferença maior do que vocês falavam que ia ser”. The message, coded as a coordination instruction with markers of militarization and urgency, summarizes the two operations described throughout this report: the coordination of future tasks and the retroactive production of social proof in favor of the issuer itself — a dynamic recorded by BBC News Brasil (26/10/2026) as a hallmark of Janones’s activity.

Recruitment and targets from 20 to 23 October

In the final week, the reopening of the channel was associated with growth targets. On 20 October, audio files and texts made reopening conditional on the target of 7 million subscribers and disseminated the channel link (E8). Between 22 and 23 October, invitation messages tailored to different recipients circulated, maintaining the target of expanding the channel and the request for sharing. (E9) Some examples of these messages are:

Individual invitation: “Oi meu amigo! Tudo bem? O Lula tá quase virando a eleição e a gente tá mobilizando todo mundo que vota nele em um canal no WhatsApp! [...] Entra lá? E se puder envia pra quem você conhece e que sabe que vota nele.”

Invitation directed to a female friend: “Oi amiga! Tudo bem? [...] A gente tem chegar a DEZ MILHÕES de pessoas no canal até amanhã 11 da noite! E está faltando pouco!! Entra lá? E se puder envia pra quem você conhece e que sabe que vota nele, por favor?”

Invitation to groups: “Oi grupo! Tudo bem com vocês? [...] Quem aqui do grupo que for eleitor dele entra lá? E se puder envia também pra quem vocês conhecem e que sabem que vota nele, por favor?”

According to press reports published during the window itself, the channel grew from approximately 3,5 million subscribers on 11 October to 5 million on the 17th, 6 million on the 20th, 7 million on the 21st, and 10 million on 23 October (CartaCapital, 23/10/2026; BNews, 22/10/2026), reaching approximately 10,8 million by the end of the period (BBC News Brasil, 26/10/2026). These counts, produced outside the corpus, externally corroborate the magnitude of the recruitment targets analyzed above, without constituting a measure of this research.

The examples show that recruitment was not limited to disseminating the link: the messages were formulated for different interactional contexts and requested both the entry of new participants and the redistribution of the invitation. The target of reaching ten million people, stated explicitly in the messages, also lent urgency to the request. In the full coding, 39 units were classified with the conversion/recruitment function.

The segmentation of invitations and the incentive for recirculation characterize digital activist work directed toward expanding the communicative infrastructure of mobilization (Kreiss, 2016; Karpf, 2016). The episode thus records an attempt to convert contingent communicative activity into an expanded base of subscribers. The corpus, however, does not permit an assessment of the retention of these participants or a determination of whether the intended growth translated into enduring organizational capacity (Tufekci, 2017).

Limitations of the analyses

The corpus constitutes a channel snapshot, not the universe of digital activism in the period; it therefore does not support generalizations about the campaign, pro-Lula activism, or WhatsApp users.

The full coding covers 16–25 October; the days from 5 to 15 October were incorporated only into the window metrics (posts, media, URLs), not into the qualitative coding.

Observable coordination is not equivalent to reach, measured adherence, electoral impact, automation, fake profiles, engagement purchases, or illegality. None of these hypotheses can be affirmed or ruled out with the available material.

Subscriber counts for the channel reported in the press (approximately 10,8 million at the peak, according to BBC News Brasil of 26/10/2026) were not measured in this research: they are numbers reported by the platforms and cited only as context. Subscribers are not equivalent to reach, reading, or electoral impact. Political claims recorded in the corpus (e.g., E10) are analyzed as published content, not as verified fact.

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